

Bulk Buying 101

Most of us have known for some time that purchasing in bulk provides decent financial returns. The problem? Bulk buying sounds way simpler than it actually is. Where do you store it? When does it make sense to buy in bulk versus small quantities?

It's enough to make your eyes cross and your brain start to feel pickled, particularly if you've never shopped this way before. What's more, it's far from the sexiest financial subject matter out there, which can make it very difficult to analyze and apply to your personal situation. Here's a nuts-and-bolts article covering what I see as the five major areas of consideration.

1. Storage

What to store it in?

Some items actually come in packaging that makes them easily stored as is. For those that don't, the first order of business is making sure the container is as airtight as possible. From there, the next level is bulk storage versus daily usage containers. For the larger amounts of things, I like the 5 and 25-gallon

white plastic buckets with the matching snap-on lids.

While the larger buckets are great for safe long-term storage of large-quantity dry goods, they can be a bit cumbersome for daily use. For easy grab-and-use access in the kitchen, I love clear containers. These can take a variety of forms depending on your personal taste and budget. What's important is that you have manageable access to things you need on a regular basis, such as sugar, tea, spices, flour, beans, coffee, etc.

Freezer issues are a bit different, but the overall concepts still apply. Some things can get tossed in as is, using only the packaging they were purchased with. Others might require freezer storage bags.

Where to store it?

Where to store it requires flexibility and ingenuity, particularly since everyone's situation is different. Here are three ideas I think everyone can use to some extent:

Sleep on it. Literally.

Pick up a set of bed risers and create a pantry from the unused real estate under your bed. If you really want to get fancy, you can invest in some wheeled under-the-bed storage containers, or make your own out of mismatched dresser drawers and castor wheels. If not, just go with the raising-up-on-risers trick and go